Speaking into Sacred Silence: The Sanhedrin as a Metaphor of Patriarchal Control within Church Spaces in Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie's *Purple Hibiscus* and Ayọbámi Adébáyọ̀'s *Stay with Me"*

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Abstract
This study examines patriarchal control and the silencing of women in African church-related contexts through a comparative analysis of Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie's *Purple Hibiscus* and Ayọbámi Adébáyọ̀'s *Stay with Me*. Although Christian institutions are frequently framed as moral communities grounded in justice and spiritual equality, women's participation often remains confined to supportive roles, while authority is consolidated within male-dominated structures. To interrogate this contradiction, the study introduces the metaphor of the Sanhedrin as a conceptual model for understanding how formal and informal councils of male authority regulate voice, legitimacy, and participation under the guise of sacred order. Grounded in African Feminist Literary Theory and African Feminist Theology, the research adopts a qualitative textual methodology based on close reading and thematic analysis. The findings reveal that patriarchal control in the selected novels operates through religious absolutism, cultural expectations, and emotional regulation, encouraging women to internalize submission and to perform joy despite exclusion. Women's silence emerges not as passive consent but as a survival strategy within systems that socialize male dominance. The study contributes to scholarship on gender and religion in Africa by developing the Sanhedrin metaphor as an interpretive tool for analyzing patriarchal councils within sacred and socio-cultural spaces. It demonstrates that contemporary African fiction functions as a critical site for exposing the ethical tension between spiritual rhetoric and institutional inequality, while recovering suppressed female voices and reimagining agency within constrained religious environments.
Keywords: Patriarchal Control; Silencing of Women; Sanhedrin Metaphor; African Feminist Literary Theory; African Feminist Theology; Female Agency.

Introduction
Religious institutions are often imagined as moral communities grounded in justice, compassion, and shared spiritual worth. In many Christian church spaces across Africa, these ideals coexist uneasily with enduring gendered hierarchies that structure access to authority, legitimacy, and voice. Women constitute the numerical majority of congregants and remain central to the economic, emotional, and organizational life of churches. They finance church projects, sustain prayer groups and welfare ministries, organize rituals, and provide the affective labor that holds religious communities together. Yet, despite this centrality, women's participation is routinely circumscribed by institutional arrangements that confine them to supportive and auxiliary roles while excluding them from formal leadership, doctrinal interpretation, and decision-making processes. Authority is consolidated within male-dominated ecclesiastical councils that regulate who

may speak, who may lead, and whose experiences are granted theological significance. As the rabbinic legal tradition observes, "A judge who renders a true judgment, even for a single hour, is regarded as though he were a partner with the Holy One, blessed be He, in the work of creation" (Sanhedrin 7a), highlighting the sacred weight of male-mediated authority. The result is a persistent paradox in which women are called to serve faithfully and give generously, yet are denied meaningful agency within the very institutions they sustain.

This paradox is reinforced not only through organizational structures but also through discursive and affective practices that naturalize inequality. From the pulpit, in pastoral counseling, and within everyday church interactions, women are frequently exhorted to embody virtues of patience, humility, endurance, and joy in the face of exclusion. Marginalization is reframed as spiritual discipline, and discontent is moralized as spiritual failure. The gravity attributed to religious judgment within sacred institutions is echoed in another Talmudic assertion: "Whoever destroys a single life is considered by Scripture as if he had destroyed an entire world; and whoever saves a single life is considered as if he had saved an entire world" (Sanhedrin 37a). Such rhetoric functions to depoliticize gendered exclusion by presenting it as divine order rather than as historically produced arrangements of power. The injunction to "be joyful" in restricted spaces thus becomes an affective technology of governance, shaping how women are expected to feel about their own marginalization. Through this emotional regulation, dissent is rendered morally suspect, while compliance is sanctified as faithfulness. Women are not only institutionally marginalized but affectively disciplined into accepting the terms of their exclusion.

These contemporary church practices are particularly striking when situated against longer histories of women's resistance to social, economic, and political marginalization in African societies. African feminist historiography documents how women have organized collectively against colonial exploitation, economic exclusion, patriarchal customary laws, and postcolonial political marginalization. Women's political protests, market-based solidarities, and social movements demonstrate that subordination has never gone uncontested. The persistence of women's exclusion from authority within church spaces, therefore, does not reflect cultural inevitability or spiritual consensus but rather a selective forgetting of historical struggles against gendered domination. This institutional amnesia allows patriarchal authority to be continually re-legitimized as sacred order, detached from the longer genealogies of resistance that challenge its moral authority.

It is within this context that contemporary African fiction becomes a vital critical archive for examining the everyday operations of religious patriarchy. Literary narratives register the affective, psychological, and moral consequences of ecclesiastical power in ways that institutional discourse often conceals. In *Purple Hibiscus*, Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie constructs a domestic and religious environment governed by absolutist moral authority, where Christian devotion becomes a technology of discipline regulating speech, bodily comportment, and dissent, particularly among women and children. The novel exposes how religious ideals of purity and obedience are mobilized to legitimate patriarchal violence and silence, revealing the intimate entanglement of spiritual authority with coercive control. Similarly, *Stay with Me* by Ayọbámi Adébáyọ̀ depicts a

socio-religious milieu in which women's bodies, fertility, and reproductive choices are regulated through expectations sanctified by faith, kinship structures, and communal surveillance. Female suffering is normalized, endurance is elevated as moral excellence, and silence becomes a condition of social acceptance. Such regulation resonates with older religious notions of collective moral responsibility, expressed in the Talmudic maxim: "All Israel are responsible for one another" (Sanhedrin 27b). Across both texts, women are encouraged explicitly and implicitly to endure marginalization with grace, mirroring the affective discipline prevalent within many church spaces.

These literary representations illuminate how religious power is reproduced not only through doctrine or policy but also through everyday practices of emotional management, moral persuasion, and symbolic control. Fiction, in this sense, does not merely reflect church life; it theorizes the affective economies through which patriarchy is sustained. By foregrounding women's interior struggles, narrative silences, and constrained agency, African fiction reveals how spiritual authority operates at the level of feeling as much as at the level of institutional structure.

It is against this backdrop that the central problem addressed in this article emerges. Despite extensive scholarship on women's marginalization in religious institutions, existing studies have largely focused on doctrinal debates, ecclesiastical policies, or formal exclusions from leadership. Less attention has been paid to how patriarchal authority in African churches is culturally reproduced through affective governance, moral rhetoric, and everyday practices of silencing, particularly as these processes are theorized within African literary texts. Consequently, the emotional and narrative technologies through which women's exclusion is normalized in religious life remain under-analyzed. This lacuna limits our understanding of how religious patriarchy persists not only as an institutional arrangement but as a lived moral experience.

In response to this problem, this article examines how African fiction theorizes patriarchal control in Christian church spaces through a metaphorical framework conceptualized here as the *Sanhedrin*. In Jewish legal history, the Sanhedrin represented the highest council of judicial and religious authority, where decisions were invested with sacred significance. As one rabbinic teaching states, "A judge who renders a true judgment… is regarded as though he were a partner with the Holy One in the work of creation" (Sanhedrin 7a). The Sanhedrin, as an analytic metaphor, captures both formal leadership structures and informal regimes of moral surveillance that determine whose voices are recognized as spiritually authoritative. The article pursues three objectives: first, to analyze how religious authority is represented in selected African novels as a form of patriarchal discipline; second, to examine how affective injunctions to joy, patience, and endurance function as technologies of silencing; and third, to demonstrate how literary texts expose the ethical contradictions of spiritualized inequality.

By situating literary representation alongside historical and contemporary church realities, this study contributes to ongoing debates on gender, religion, and power in African societies. It extends feminist theological critiques by foregrounding the affective and narrative dimensions of religious authority and advances African literary scholarship by reading fiction as a site of theoretical production about institutional power. Ultimately, ethical reflection on religious life must reckon not only with doctrine and policy but with the emotional regimes through which inequality is normalized and resistance is rendered

morally illegible. By foregrounding women's silenced voices and narrated suffering, the study affirms literature as a crucial site for contesting narratives that equate submission with spiritual virtue and for imagining more just configurations of religious community.

Review of Related Literature

Scholarly discussions on gender and religion consistently identify Christian institutions as critical sites where patriarchal authority is sustained and normalised. In African contexts, particularly Nigeria, studies demonstrate that church leadership structures often reproduce cultural hierarchies that restrict women's access to voice, authority, and decision-making. Olayinka argues that religious institutions frequently mirror broader societal power relations, privileging male leadership while framing women's exclusion as divinely ordained or culturally appropriate (42–44). Such practices, he notes, undermine the church's moral claims to justice and equality.

Nigerian scholars examining Christianity and gender further observe that women's participation in church life is often welcomed only within narrowly defined roles. Adegboye's analysis of church organisation and gender relations reveals that women are disproportionately channelled into financial, caregiving, and supportive ministries, while leadership and doctrinal authority remain male-dominated (61–63). This structural imbalance creates what Adegboye describes as "participatory visibility without institutional power," a condition that sustains women's marginalisation even as their labour remains indispensable.

Relatedly, Musa's study of religion and social control in Nigerian Christian communities highlights how sermons and church teachings frequently emphasise submission, patience, and joy for women, particularly in contexts of exclusion. According to Musa, this theological framing discourages critical engagement with injustice and instead promotes emotional endurance as a spiritual virtue (78–80). Women are thus urged to remain content within systems that deny them equal participation, reinforcing silence as both moral and religious discipline.

From a historical perspective, Nigerian feminist historians caution against the assumption that women's marginalisation is an unbroken tradition. Achebe's work on women's political and ritual authority in southeastern Nigeria demonstrates that precolonial and early colonial societies contained mechanisms through which women exercised collective power and resisted exclusion (109–12). Contemporary feminist readings interpret these histories as evidence that women's silencing in modern institutions—including churches—is neither natural nor inevitable, but the result of selective cultural and religious reinterpretations.

Ezeanya extends this argument by examining how religious modernity in Nigeria has reconfigured gender relations in ways that often disadvantage women. She argues that while Christianity introduced new moral frameworks, it also consolidated patriarchal leadership models that marginalised women from formal authority, even when women formed the numerical and economic backbone of congregations (94–96). This paradox remains visible in many church settings where women's contributions are celebrated financially but restricted institutionally.

Literary criticism provides a vital avenue for interrogating these realities. Nigerian and African feminist critics argue that fiction exposes the emotional, spiritual, and

psychological consequences of women's silencing in religious spaces. In Purple Hibiscus, Adichie depicts how religious absolutism legitimises male domination, rendering female silence a condition of survival rather than faith (Adichie 21–23). Similarly, Adébáyọ̀'s *Stay with Me* portrays a socio-religious environment in which women's bodies and voices are regulated by patriarchal expectations that are reinforced through cultural and religious norms (Adébáyọ̀ 64–66).

Collectively, these scholarly perspectives establish that patriarchal control in church spaces is sustained through institutional practices, theological narratives, and leadership structures that limit women's participation while demanding their emotional, spiritual, and financial commitment. This body of literature provides a credible foundation for the present study, which employs the metaphor of the Sahendrin to examine how African fiction represents patriarchal councils within sacred spaces and critiques the contradiction of exhorting women to joy while denying them voice and authority.

Theoretical Framework

This study is grounded in African Feminist Literary Theory and African Feminist Theology, two interrelated frameworks that interrogate how gender, power, culture, and religion intersect in African societies. These frameworks are particularly suited to a literary analysis of patriarchal control and women's silencing within church spaces because they emerge from African socio-cultural realities rather than externally imposed feminist paradigms.

African feminist literary theory emphasizes that African women's writing is deeply engaged with the structures that regulate women's lives, including family, tradition, and religion. Kolawole argues that African women writers use fiction as a space to expose how cultural and religious institutions legitimize women's marginalization while presenting such exclusion as moral or natural (Kolawole 24–26). This perspective enables the present study to read literary representations of church authority as symbolic systems through which silence and obedience are enforced. Closely aligned with this is womanism, as articulated by Ogunyemi, which recognizes the interconnectedness of gender, community, and spirituality in African contexts. Ogunyemi maintains that African womanism does not reject family or religion but challenges power relations that disguise domination as harmony or complementarity (72–75). Within church spaces, appeals to peace, submission, and joy often function as ideological tools that suppress women's voices. Womanist theory therefore provides a critical lens for examining how religious discourse encourages women to endure marginalization while remaining emotionally compliant.

African feminist theology further deepens this analysis by interrogating the theological foundations of gender exclusion. Oduyoye contends that patriarchal dominance in African Christianity is not divinely mandated but historically constructed through selective biblical interpretation and missionary influence (Oduyoye 12–15). She argues that women's exclusion from preaching and decision-making contradicts both African communal ethics and Christian principles of justice. This framework is essential for analyzing how church elders operate as custodians of spiritual authority while restricting women's participation.

Historical feminist scholarship by Amadiume provides an additional dimension by demonstrating that many African societies once recognized female authority before colonial and missionary interventions reshaped gender relations. Amadiume's work shows that colonial Christianity reinforced rigid patriarchal structures that continue to influence modern church leadership models (Amadiume 103–06). This insight supports the study's metaphorical use of the Sahendrin to describe patriarchal councils within church spaces structures that are historical, ideological, and sustained through institutional power rather than divine necessity. These theoretical perspectives enable a nuanced literary reading of *Purple Hibiscus* and *Stay With Me* as texts that critique patriarchal control, expose the silencing of women in religious spaces, and question theological narratives that demand joy and submission amid exclusion. The framework affirms literature as a critical site for examining how women negotiate voice, faith, and resistance within church structures governed by male authority.

Methodology

This study adopts a qualitative literary approach, focusing on the interpretation and critical analysis of selected fictional texts. The methodology is rooted in African feminist literary criticism and African feminist theology, which provide frameworks for examining how narratives portray patriarchal authority, religious influence, and the silencing of women in church spaces. The primary texts for analysis are Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie's *Purple Hibiscus* and Ayọbámi Adébáyọ̀'s *Stay With Me*. These novels were selected for their engagement with themes of gendered power, religious authority, and women's constrained agency. The study reads the texts closely to explore narrative strategies, characterization, dialogue, and symbolic representation that reveal the operation of patriarchal control and the enforcement of silence within religiously informed social spaces.

The analysis employs the metaphor of the Sanhedrin to conceptualize patriarchal councils of authority within the texts. This metaphor allows for a focus on how male-dominated structures regulate voice, participation, and legitimacy in church-related contexts, and how women navigate, resist, or internalize these restrictions. Interpretation is conducted thematically, identifying patterns of exclusion, obedience, and resistance, as well as the contradictions between spiritual exhortations and social practice.

This approach treats the novels as cultural and ideological texts, offering insight into the dynamics of gender, religion, and power in African societies. The study remains confined to literary analysis, without attempting empirical generalizations, and situates its findings within broader African feminist perspectives on religion and patriarchy.

Analysis

A comparative reading of *Purple Hibiscus* and *Stay with Me* reveals how patriarchal authority operates through both religious and socio-cultural systems to regulate women's voices, choices, and identities. Though the novels differ in narrative, focus and narrative texture, they converge in their exposure of male-dominated structures that function like a symbolic Sanhedrin, a council of authority that determines legitimacy, obedience, and silence. In both texts, women are not entirely voiceless; rather, their voices are strategically managed, deferred, and disciplined into socially acceptable forms.

In *Purple Hibiscus*, patriarchal authority is overtly enforced through religious absolutism. Eugene Achike's authority derives from his fusion of domestic patriarchy with rigid Catholic doctrine, positioning him as the unquestionable moral arbiter within both the household and the church-aligned social order. His understanding of faith permits no dialogue or interpretive plurality, especially for women. Kambili observes that "Papa's voice was like the voice of God, telling us what to do" (Adichie 22), a statement that collapses paternal authority into divine authority. This conflation socializes patriarchy, making resistance appear not merely disobedient but sinful. Beatrice's silence is similarly cultivated through fear and religious justification. After a violent episode that leads to her miscarriage, she is described as moving "quietly around the house, her eyes lowered, her lips pressed together" (Adichie 41). Silence here is not natural temperament but an affective posture produced by terror and sanctified discipline. This exemplifies what African feminist scholarship describes as the socialization of patriarchy, in which male authority is framed as divinely ordained and therefore insulated from critique.

The cultivation of women's silence in *Purple Hibiscus* mirrors ecclesiastical practices in which women are urged to embody submission and endurance while being excluded from interpretive and leadership roles. Beatrice's role as a devout wife is confined to support, loyalty, and sacrifice, even when that sacrifice entails physical harm. After Eugene beats her for "sinning," the narrative notes that Beatrice later "knelt by the bed and prayed for Papa, thanking God for his strength" (Adichie 50). The affective contradiction is striking: gratitude is demanded in the very moment of abuse. This enforced gratitude exemplifies what Obioma Nnaemeka terms a "culture of enforced compliance," in which women's survival within patriarchal systems depends on strategic silence rather than open confrontation. Beatrice's eventual act of resistance poisoning Eugene is significant precisely because it ruptures a religious and domestic order that had rendered her suffering morally invisible.

While *Purple Hibiscus* situates patriarchal dominance within an explicitly religious framework, *Stay with Me* examines how similar logics operate through cultural and marital expectations surrounding motherhood. Yejide's social worth is persistently measured by her reproductive capacity. She reflects bitterly that "a woman who could not give her husband a child was not a woman at all" (Adébáyọ̀ 34). Though, Christian discourse is less foregrounded than in *Purple Hibiscus*. Patriarchal authority manifests through family elders, marital customs, and communal surveillance, collectively functioning as a Sanhedrin-like structure that governs women's legitimacy. Decisions about Yejide's body are routinely made without her consent. When her husband's family orchestrates the arrival of a second wife, Yejide recalls being informed rather than consulted: "They had decided for us, and I was the last to know" (Adébáyọ̀ 78). This exclusion from decision-making underscores how women's lives are governed by councils of authority that operate under the guise of family and tradition.

Adébáyọ̀'s narrative further demonstrates how women's silence is normalized through emotional manipulation and cultural obligation. Yejide internalises blame for childlessness even when male infertility is concealed. She confesses, "I apologized for a fault that was not mine, because it was easier to carry shame than to cause trouble" (Adébáyọ̀ 112). This emotional displacement aligns with Molara Ogundipe-Leslie Ogunyemi's observation that African patriarchal systems often redirect social failure onto

women's bodies in order to preserve male privilege. Yejide's suffering is intensified by the expectation that she must endure quietly, preserve marital harmony, and remain grateful for partial inclusion in decisions that fundamentally structure her existence. Silence here becomes both emotional labour and moral obligation.

When read together, *Purple Hibiscus* and *Stay with Me* illuminate the continuity of patriarchal control across religious and cultural domains. The Sanhedrin metaphor captures both formal authority (priests, elders, fathers) and informal authority (custom, kinship pressure, communal expectations). In both novels, women are encouraged to be joyful, prayerful, and supportive even as they are denied meaningful participation in decisions that govern their lives. Kambili learns to measure her worth by obedience, "I wanted to be pleasing, to be good enough for Papa" (Adichie 24) just as Yejide measures hers through motherhood "I counted months the way other women counted blessings" (Adébáyọ̀ 39). These parallel affective regimes reveal how patriarchal authority disciplines women's desires and self-perceptions across different institutional terrains.

Importantly, neither novel presents women as passive victims. Kambili's gradual acquisition of voice signaled when she finally speaks publicly and laughs freely in Aunty Ifeoma's household marks a reconfiguration of subjectivity beyond religious terror: "My laughter sounded strange, even to me" (Adichie 155). Similarly, Yejide's painful self-realization "I was angry, not just at him, but at the silence I had wrapped myself in" (Adébáyọ̀ 287) signals an awakening to the costs of endurance. These moments affirm African feminist insistence that silence is not consent but often a survival strategy within hostile structures. Resistance, though constrained, emerges as affective refusal and narrative re-voicing.

Through close textual analysis, this study demonstrates that Adichie and Adébáyọ̀ critique patriarchal authority not merely as individual male dominance but as an entrenched system sustained by religion, culture, and communal silence. By framing these systems through the Sanhedrin metaphor, the study foregrounds how African fiction theorizes the persistence of gendered exclusion while imagining ethically charged moments of resistance within sacred and social spaces. Literature thus functions not only as representation but as critical epistemology, exposing the moral contradictions of spiritualized patriarchy and recovering women's suppressed voices within structures that demand their silence.

Conclusion

This study has examined how patriarchal authority, religious discourse, and socio-cultural norms intersect to regulate women's voices and agency in African Christian contexts, as represented in *Purple Hibiscus* and *Stay With Me*. Through African feminist literary theory and African feminist theology, the analysis has shown that women's silencing within religiously informed spaces is neither incidental nor natural but produced through institutional arrangements, moral rhetoric, and affective discipline. In both novels, patriarchal control operates through councils of legitimacy whether ecclesiastical, familial, or communal that regulate whose voices count, whose bodies are governed, and whose suffering is rendered morally acceptable. Women are encouraged to perform joy, patience, and spiritual contentment even as their exclusion from authority and decision-making is normalized.

By reading these dynamics through the metaphor of the Sanhedrin, this study has illuminated how patriarchal councils of authority function symbolically across religious and socio-cultural domains to legitimize gendered exclusion under the guise of sacred order and communal harmony. The Sanhedrin framework foregrounds how power is exercised not only through overt prohibition but through moral persuasion, emotional regulation, and institutional silence. This conceptual move enables a deeper understanding of how women's marginalization in church spaces is sustained affectively and discursively, rather than solely through doctrinal restriction. The novels analyzed demonstrate that silence is not equivalent to consent; rather, it often operates as a survival strategy within hostile moral economies that frame dissent as spiritual failure.

The comparative analysis further reveals that African fiction functions as a critical epistemological site through which the contradictions of religious patriarchy are exposed. Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie and Ayọbámi Adébáyọ̀ do not merely represent women's suffering within religiously inflected social worlds; they theorize the affective technologies through which such suffering is normalized and sustained. By centering women's interiority, narrative silences, and constrained acts of resistance, both texts challenge theological and cultural narratives that equate submission with virtue and endurance with moral excellence. The novels thereby unsettle the ethical foundations of spiritualized inequality and recover women's silenced experiences as sites of critique.

This study makes three principal contributions to literary and interdisciplinary scholarship: First, it introduces the Sahendrin as an original analytic metaphor for understanding patriarchal governance in African religious and socio-cultural contexts. By conceptualising male-dominated councils of authority as symbolic formations that regulate voice, legitimacy, and emotional conduct, the study offers a new theoretical tool for analysing how power operates in African fiction beyond individual acts of male dominance. Second, the study advances African feminist literary criticism by foregrounding affective governance as a central mechanism of women's silencing in religious spaces. While existing scholarship has extensively examined exclusion from leadership and doctrinal authority, this study shows how injunctions to joy, patience, and spiritual fulfilment function as emotional technologies that stabilise inequality. This shifts critical attention from formal prohibition to the moral and emotional regimes through which patriarchy is normalised in narrative representation. Third, by placing African feminist theology in sustained dialogue with literary analysis, the study extends the scope of religious critique in African literature. It demonstrates how fiction not only reflects ecclesiastical practices but actively theorises the ethical contradictions of Christian patriarchy in African contexts. In doing so, the article contributes to interdisciplinary debates on gender, religion, and power by positioning African women's writing as a site of theoretical production rather than merely illustrative cultural commentary.

Ultimately, this study affirms literature as a crucial space for interrogating the moral economies of religious life and for challenging narratives that render women's exclusion spiritually virtuous. Trough an examination of how patriarchal authority is reproduced through councils of legitimacy, affective discipline, and institutional silence, the article calls for more ethically attentive readings of religion in African literary studies readings that take women's silenced experiences seriously as sites of critique, resistance, and theoretical insight.

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